

PANKA NANGIA



## The Last Encounter

**DELHI** With over 50 encounters to his name and controversy in tow, Delhi's ACP Rajbir Singh could have easily given Dirty Harry a run for his money. But on the night of March 24, property dealer Vijay Bharadwaj allegedly shot him dead at point blank range over a land dispute in Gurgaon. Reports indicate that Bharadwaj owed Singh around Rs 70 lakh. March 24 was pay-up day. A fight ensued with Singh threat-

ening Bharadwaj who allegedly picked up a gun Singh had given him three days earlier and shot him dead.

Singh's end was as dramatic as his meteoric rise through the ranks of the Delhi Police—from a sub-inspector to an ACP in a mere 13 years. He had five awards including the President's Police Medal for Gallantry to his credit. Posted to the Special Cell, an anti-terrorism unit of the capital's police force, it

### ENDGAME: Singh

was the 56 "encounters"—some suspected to be false—that brought him both recognition and controversy. The most controversial one was the Ansal Plaza encounter on Diwali eve in November 2002, where two suspected Lashkar-e-Toiba militants were shot dead by Singh and his team. It was murder and the encounter was a fake, an eyewitness had later said.

Singh was also the man credited with the investigation into the terrorist attacks on the Red Fort in 2000 and Parliament in 2001. He also cracked the city's first cocaine deal case. There were also allegations of his links to land mafia, bookies and drug dealers, following which he was transferred from the Crime Branch to the Delhi Armed Police, a fall from grace from his earlier coveted posts. He was reinstated in November 2007 after being given a clean chit by the Vigilance Department. He then rejoined the Crime Branch to head the Special Operations Squad.

by Chitra Subramanyam

### SIGNPOSTS

**SOLD:** For a record \$1.6 million (Rs 6.4 crore), **M.F. Hussain's** painting titled *Battle of Ganga and Yamuna: Mahabharata 12*, at an auction at Christie's in New York. It was the highest price fetched by a painting by an Indian.



**DIED:** Justice Jagmohan Lal Sinha, 87, who set aside the election of former prime minis-

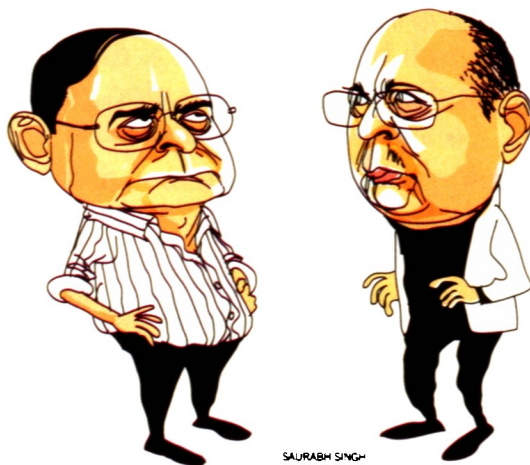
ter Indira Gandhi from Rae Bareilly in 1975. She retaliated by imposing a national Emergency on June 25, 1975.

**SENTENCED:** To life imprisonment, **R.K. Sharma** for the murder of journalist Shivani Bhatnagar on January 23, 1999. He is the first IPS officer to be convicted for murder.

**DIED:** Justice K.G. Shah, 73, a member of the Shah-Nanavati Commission, which is investigating the Godhra carnage and riots thereafter.

**VIS-A-VIS** ARUN JAITLEY BJP leader versus ABHISHEK SINGHVI Congress spokesperson

**Rahul Gandhi's unsuccessful UP campaign is proof of his ability. Nothing succeeds in the Congress like failure.**



**If Rahul Gandhi is the basis of the BJP's campaign, we feel sorry for them. BJP shouldn't fight polls on such superficial comparisons.**

**EPILOGUE:** Superficial yes, but all parties fight polls on superficial grounds these days.